



by becoming the first Indian batter to score 150 and pick five wickets in the same match in List A cricket. In another stunning record, Punjab registered the biggest win in List A cricket by balls remaining when it overhauled Nagaland's 75 with 275 balls to spare.

It wasn't always smooth sailing for the traditional heavyweights against the less-fancied teams. Wriddhiman Saha may be in the twilight of his career, but he ushered in a new dawn for Tripura cricket, leading the side to two remarkable victories against defending champion Saurashtra and Mumbai.

Manisankar Murasingh's all-round brilliance in both games — he scored a combined 80 runs and picked up six wickets in the two wins — could mean cricket in the Northeast may have its first homegrown poster boy.

The Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, which ended in early November, indicated that T20 domestic cricket in India was in sync with international

Worthy opponents: Dinesh Karthik (left) and Ajinkya Rahane may be past their prime in international cricket but were entrusted with the captaincy of Tamil Nadu and Mumbai, respectively, in the Vijay Hazare Trophy. VIJAY SONEJI

trends as far as the emphasis on scoring briskly was concerned. However, the 50-over domestic tournament seemed incongruous with the evolving ways of One-Day International cricket. Out of the 135 matches, or 270 potential batting innings, scheduled for the Vijay Hazare Trophy, teams touched or breached the 300-run mark only 23 times.

If the recently concluded ICC ODI World Cup is a touchstone for where one-day cricket is headed, teams surpassed the 300-run mark on 25 occasions in a 48-match tournament.

Though day games with an early morning start, when the ball swings prodigiously, especially with the onset of winter, played a part in reining in the scoring rates, openers were often found wanting in technique and intent in the first

PowerPlay. Thus, the onus was on consolidation against spin in the middle overs and the finishers to crank through the gears in the last 10 overs. **The likes of Sumit, Manoj Bhandage, Vishnu Vinod, Abdul Basith, and Rahul Tewatia, in the second regard, ably stepped up to the challenge.**

Indian cricket has grown a little wary of winning streaks of late. But either Haryana or Rajasthan, on eight and nine-match winning streaks, respectively, ahead of the final, was bound to emerge unblemished. Haryana eventually extended its unbeaten run to 10 matches, leaving Rajasthan with the solitary consolation of arguably being the better team. That argument, as the recent past has shown, does little to dampen the spirits of the champion.